



ON THE WRITE LINE

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STORIES

WE HAVE BEEN BRAINWASHED INTO ACCEPTING TRAMPOLINE BOUNCE IN AUSTRALIA AND CATTLE-GRAZING PITCHES IN ENGLAND

The **irony** is that if it is a pitch where not too many wickets fall but plenty of runs are scored, then the match referee more often than not gives it a poor rating.

Another Test match in Australia has finished in less than two days of cricket. The Australian Cricket Board's CEO says it is not good business, and most, if not all, cricket fans in the sub-continent (read India) are screaming blue murder about the quality of the pitch given in Melbourne. They were astonished when the first Test match pitch in Perth received a very good rating from the match referee, Ranjan Madugalle. Since there is a new match referee, Jeff Crowe, for the Melbourne and Sydney Test matches, the rating could be different. Since 36 wickets fell in the Melbourne Test instead of 32 in Perth, Crowe might drop the word 'very' from the 'very good' that Madugalle gave for the Perth pitch and rate the MCG pitch as good. Surprises never cease, of course, so we may get another rating.

Since he is a Kiwi, and we all know that the Kiwi vs Aussie clashes often have more passion in them than an Ashes contest, since the latter have become boringly predictable, will the Kiwi in him want to let the Aussies have it? But then Crowe now lives in the USA, so the passion may have calmed down a bit. That said, with tongue firmly in cheek, have we not all been

brainwashed over the years that when you tour Australia, you must expect trampoline-like bounce and not moan about it, and when you go to the UK, then you must expect cattle-grazing patches masquerading as cricket pitches and not whinge about it either?

The curators, or as we found out about the person in charge at the MCG, the Director of Turf, may make a human error and get it slightly wrong, but they are not as devious as those 'horrible groundsmen' in India who do not even prepare a pitch and expect the batters to score runs on it. Tut tut.

So, if anything, let us not argue about the pitches but simply accept that it is the batting that needs to be looked at. How many batters today play late and with soft hands? How many players bat off the back foot so they can get that extra little second to decide to play or leave the ball? With the restriction of two bouncers per over, the batters today are on the front foot even before the quick bowler has taken the fourth step of his run-up.

The boundaries being shortened to allow for the sliding stop, and the big bats and bulging muscles, mean that no batter is going to block more than three or four deliveries before trying